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Arsenal hope dwindles after PSG show different side to see off Bayern Munich

Arsenal are in real trouble after Paris Saint-Germain showed a different, very alarming side to see off Bayern Munich and book their place in the Champions League final.

The absurd quality of the footballers on show at the Allianz Arena was epitomised by early doubts as to whether twinkle-toed Jamal Musiala had a sure enough touch for this level, if renowned speedster Dayot Upamecano had the required pace and 51 G/A Michael Olise the necessary composure in the final third.

Bayern Munich were just slightly slower to the ball than Paris Saint-Germain, who discovered relative and unlikely comfort in a game after [the first-leg madness](#) having sliced through the hosts in devastating, entirely PSG-like fashion inside three minutes.

“I’ve been there,” Steven Gerrard said in sympathy with Warren Zaire-Emery, with his own evident demons in mind as a midfielder who operated at right-back on occasion for Liverpool, having watched Achraf Hakimi’s stand-in attempt to cope with Luis Diaz while Bayern right-back Konrad Laimer was dazzled Khvicha Kvaratskhelia.

The first-time passes, first from Kvaratskhelia and then Fabian Ruiz, to get the flying Georgian in behind were both superb, as was Ousmane Dembele’s movement in the box to free himself of Bayern defenders before side-footing his shot above Manuel Neuer into the roof of the net.

In teeing up Dembele, Kvaratskhelia became the first player to score or assist in seven consecutive knockout stage appearances in the same Champions League season. Only Harry Kane (22) after his stoppage-time bullet into the top corner has been directly involved in more Champions League goals than his 21 (13 goals, eight assists) since signing from Napoli in February 2025.

Frequent visitors to these pages will have seen plenty of frustration over [daft Champions League handball decisions ruining games and thus football](#). We are however fully in favour of the ball to João Neves’ arm being punished, not least because it exposes him and Vitorino as mere mortals capable of mistakes.

The IFAB ruling is that ‘it is not a handball if a player is hit on the hand/arm by the ball from a teammate’s kick/header’.

Quite why a line is drawn between ga shot or cross striking an opponents arm and a player on the same team smashing a clearance onto an arm we don’t know. One involves a mistake; the other is pure misfortune.

That moment and one a few seconds before when Vincent Kompany, his players and 70-odd thousand Bavarians in the Allianz Arena were bellowing for Nuno Mendes to be shown a second yellow for another ball to arm was as lively as Bayern got for 94 minutes of a game we might suggest they bottled if we a) were forcing ourselves into using the parlance of the season and b) PSG weren’t one of the best football teams we’ve ever had the pleasure of watching.

Kvaratskhelia and Desire Doue could and perhaps should have increased the Ligue 1 side’s advantage with an uncanny ability to make opportunities for themselves in what was a far less end-

to-end display and thus less exciting game of football compared to the Parcs des Princes mania, but one which highlighted the serious side of a serious football team.

They're the best team in the world on and off the ball, and while Arsenal will be heralded as the superior defensive force ahead of the final, this was an impeccable display from Marquinhos and Willian Pacho to match William Saliba and Gabriel, while we saw the development of Zaire-Emery at right-back in real time as he had Diaz's number in the second half.

Arsenal would have preferred Bayern after ripping them apart at the Emirates in November. They would also have been encouraged had PSG progressed to the final after a second-leg shootout similar to the first on the basis of their defence being so much stronger than Bayern's and able to withstand PSG's attacking brilliance amid hope of a chance or five through their soft centre.

Instead they've witnessed PSG very nearly keep a clean sheet against a Bayern side that's scored 191 goals in 57 games this season while racking up 15 shots and looking just as likely score themselves.

They will be the best team Arsenal have played this season or in any season since the Mikel Arteta project started. Anything other than a perfect performance won't be enough and even then the Gunners will fall short if PSG reach their now standard, ridiculously high level.

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